

From Dew to Delight: The Story of Malaiyo

Varanasi, the city of ancient temples and vibrant spiritual traditions, also boasts a unique culinary treasure: Malaiyo. This ethereal dessert, enjoyed only during the winter months, holds a special place in the hearts of locals and visitors alike.

A Delicate Creation

Malaiyo translates to "cream" in Hindi, aptly describing its key ingredient. Unlike its richer cousin, Rabdi, Malaiyo boasts a lighter and airier texture, akin to whipped cream. This unique texture is achieved through a meticulous process, heavily reliant on the natural elements.

The Art of Making Malaiyo

1. ***The Dance of Dew:*** The preparation starts the evening before, with full-cream milk boiled in large open vessels. These vessels are then left overnight under the open sky, allowing the cool winter dew to settle on the milk's surface. This crucial step is believed to contribute to the characteristic frothiness of Malaiyo.
2. ***Dawn of Churning:*** Early in the morning, skilled hands take over, churning the milk using a traditional wooden churner. This process can last for several hours, requiring patience and expertise to achieve the desired consistency – a light and fluffy foam.
3. ***A Touch of Sweetness:*** Once the desired texture is achieved, sugar is added to taste, along with a sprinkle of cardamom powder and saffron for a touch of warmth and aroma.
4. ***Garnishing for Elegance:*** Finally, Malaiyo is served in small earthenware cups, often garnished with chopped nuts like pistachios and almonds, adding a touch of visual appeal and textural contrast.

A Seasonal Delight

The delicate nature of Malaiyo's preparation makes it a seasonal treat, available only during the cooler months of November to March. The reliance on natural dew and the time-consuming manual process contribute to its limited availability, making it even more cherished by those fortunate enough to experience it.

A Cultural Experience

Savoring malaiyo is more than just a culinary experience; it's a window into Varanasi's cultural heritage and the resourcefulness of its people. It's a testament to the unique flavors that emerge from local traditions and the skillful interaction with nature's elements.

A Bite of History

The origins of Malaiyo remain unclear, but its presence in Varanasi can be traced back generations. Some believe it originated during the Mughal era, while others attribute it to the Maratha influence. Regardless of its origin, Malaiyo has become an integral part of Varanasi's culinary landscape, cherished by locals and a delightful surprise for travelers seeking unique flavor experiences.

Where to Find

While malaiyo is readily available throughout Varanasi, you can find it in below specific locations during the winter season;

- **Markandey Ki Malaiyo, Chaukhamba Gali:** Located opposite Gopal Ji Mandir in Chaukhamba Gali, is known for its authentic Malaiyo prepared according to traditional methods. Be aware that this shop might have limited seating and can get crowded during peak hours.
- **Shreeji Sweets & Milk, Chaukhamba:** Located in Garwasi tola, Chaukhamba, Varanasi, famous for its traditional sweets and snacks, shreeji is a must-visit for Malaiyo enthusiasts looking for an authentic taste.
- **Pehlwan Lassi, Lanka:** Located at Ravidas Chauraha on Lanka Road, this shop serves lip-

smacking hand-whipped Lassi and Malaiyo in kulhads, and has been upholding its traditional style of making the beverage since 1950.

So, if you find yourself in Varanasi during the winter months, be sure to seek out this ethereal dessert. Malaiyo is more than just a sweet treat; it's a cultural experience, a testament to the city's rich heritage, and a delightful bite of winter in the vibrant city of Varanasi.

Pro-tip: Be prepared to arrive early, as this delicacy often sells out quickly.